

Performative Rebel Governance and Legibility: Evidence from Rebel Recruitment in Southeast Turkey*

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Abstract

Rebel groups engage in performative governance acts that mimic the symbolic repertoires of sovereign states, such as martyr funerals or mass demonstrations. How do these acts shape civilian participation in rebellion? I conceptualize performative rebel governance as a legibility-oriented strategy through which rebels map civilian loyalties beyond their immediate networks. Voluntary participation in public acts allows rebels to identify potential supporters who might otherwise remain outside the movement, including women and politically inactive individuals. At the same time, these acts increase the visibility of rebellion to the state, exposing participants to surveillance and raising the costs of mobilization. Using a difference-in-differences design that combines original data on PKK fighter funerals in Southeast Turkey with individual-level recruitment data, I show that rebel funerals expand recruitment among “harder-to-reach” groups while reducing overall mobilization. Rebel governance in contested spaces thus entails a dilemma: efforts to increase legibility also increase legibility to the state.

Keywords: rebel recruitment, rebel governance, mobilization in civil war

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“The inability to tell friend from enemy is a recurring element of irregular war.”
—Kalyvas (2006, p. 89)

1 Introduction

Rebels engage in public acts that mimic the performative repertoires of sovereign states, including commemorations, funerals for fallen fighters, and mass demonstrations (Mampilly, 2011). While symbolic, these acts can perform governance functions by regulating the social and political life of civilians, consistent with Arjona’s (2015, p. 3) definition of rebel governance. Groups as diverse as the PKK in Turkey, the LTTE in Sri Lanka, FARC in Colombia, and FAFN in Côte d’Ivoire have employed such “performative governance” (Förster, 2015; Mampilly, 2015), yet we know little about how it shapes rebel–constituency ties and civilian participation in rebellion.

Whether non-state actors require territorial control to govern remains an ongoing debate. For some, territorial control is the most consequential mode of rebel rule (Kalyvas, 2006; Mampilly, 2011; Arjona, 2016; Kasfir, Frerks and Terpstra, 2017); others hold that rebels can govern without it (Loyle et al., 2021). This study contributes to the latter position. Performative governance, as I argue below, is one form rebel governance can take where territorial control is contested.

Why rebels govern through such acts has a straightforward answer in the existing literature. To survive, rebels require local support, which they typically secure through coercion or service provision. By mimicking sovereign repertoires, they can further reinforce their presence in contested spaces and foster identification with civilian constituencies, legitimizing authority and reducing reliance on coercion (Mampilly, 2015). This logic underpins canonical theories of insurgent collective action (Wood, 2003; Weinstein, 2006), wartime civilian victimization (Kalyvas, 2006), and institutionalized rebel governance through service provision, justice, or law en-

forcement (Mampilly, 2011; Arjona, 2016; Stewart, 2021).

Yet while studies of rebel-led victimization and service provision are abundant, performative rebel governance remains underdeveloped, and we lack systematic evidence linking performative acts to strengthened rebel–civilian relations or increased support. Moreover, recent findings challenge the legitimacy-building assumption by documenting civilian resistance to rebel governing efforts (Gowrinathan and Mampilly, 2019; Rubin, 2019; van Baalen, 2021), suggesting these consequences warrant closer scrutiny. I therefore examine how the performative aspects of rebel governance shape rebel–constituency relations and civilian participation in rebellion.

Extending social ties- and networks-centric theories of collective action, mobilization, and rebellion (Olson, 1965; McAdam, McCarthy and Zald, 1996; McAdam, Tarrow and Tilly, 2001; Siegel, 2009; Staniland, 2012; Parkinson, 2013; Staniland, 2014; Shesterinina, 2016; Lewis, 2017; Larson and Lewis, 2018; Edgerton, 2022; Nussio, 2024), I conceptualize performative rebel governance as a legibility-oriented strategy for mapping civilian loyalties in “harder-to-reach” communities: those beyond rebels’ immediate networks. Participation in symbolic public acts entails risk, making it a credible signal of loyalty that allows rebels to distinguish between civilians providing costly behavioral support to rebellion and those offering mere attitudinal sympathy.

Building on frameworks that emphasize identification problems (Kalyvas, 2006) and informational deficiencies (Obayashi, 2018) in civil war mobilization, I argue that voluntary participation serves a screening function, helping rebels identify supporters who might not otherwise mobilize, including women, non-activists, and individuals without familial ties to the movement. The theory also advances a more novel claim about the unintended consequences of this strategy. By increasing the legibility of rebellion, performative acts expose pro-rebel civilians to state surveillance and repression. As authorities monitor participation, they raise the personal costs of radicalization, deterring individuals who might have mobilized in a lower-

risk environment. The core contribution is thus to identify a central dilemma: such acts expand the mobilization base beyond traditional networks while simultaneously provoking state repression, ultimately producing an overall decline in mobilization.

This theory applies most directly to rebel groups that rely on voluntary or semi-voluntary recruitment, since coerced mobilization undermines the signaling function of public acts. It is most relevant in contested spaces, where neither rebels nor the state exercises full social and territorial control. In such environments, rebels lack the capacity to fully govern through formal administrative structures yet remain sufficiently organized to stage public acts. Finally, the argument presumes a context in which the state tolerates a public sphere, allowing public rebel acts to occur at least intermittently, with repression operating largely *ex post*. This matters because deterrence is most plausible when punishment depends on what a person does. Where repression is indiscriminate, falling on a large group of people regardless of what its members individually do, abstention buys no safety. Such a context is more likely in electoral democracies, hybrid regimes, and some autocracies that permit limited public contention, but unlikely in highly repressive authoritarian regimes.

Despite these scope conditions, the argument applies broadly. Over 70–75 percent of rebel groups have not engaged in systematic forced recruitment (Walsh, Conrad and Whitaker, 2023). Uncontested rebel territorial control is rare, and most rebel governance occurs in contested environments (Loyle et al., 2021). Moreover, civil wars disproportionately occur in flawed democracies and hybrid regimes rather than fully repressive autocracies (Hegre et al., 2001; Fearon and Laitin, 2003), a pattern that more recent work continues to locate in the hybrid, semi-democratic space (Krishnarajan et al., 2016; Orsun and Bas, 2026).

I provide evidence for this theory by combining original spatial event data on the funeral rites of PKK fighters (2012–2022) with granular microdata on PKK mobilization (2001–2022) in Southeast Turkey. Funeral data come from rebel-affiliated

news sources; mobilization data from the PKK’s official website for fallen fighters, which provides individual-level birthplaces and recruitment dates that I cross-referenced against fighter obituaries to extract demographic background. Leveraging the plausibly random location and the staggered, often delayed timing of funerals in a difference-in-differences framework, I substantiate the theorized dual effect on civilian mobilization.

Consistent with the theory, funeral rites increased the mobilization of women and individuals without prior activism or family ties to rebel in communities where they were held, expanding the rebel base beyond traditional networks of men, politicized activists, and families with prior “rebel martyrs.” At the same time, overall mobilization in those communities declined, consistent with the same acts generating countervailing effects through state surveillance and repression.

Several additional analyses support the theory. Text analysis of funeral propaganda shows the PKK framed these performances as mobilization tools; obituaries indicate funeral attendance was an important pathway to recruitment; and data on government-perpetrated civilian deaths during the 2015 curfews indicate the state responded to performative governance with violence against pro-PKK civilians. Finally, I address threats to inference through instrument-based reconstructions of the treatment, placebo tests ruling out affective mobilization, and analyses incorporating logistical constraints on funerals and survey-based measures of rebel strength and territorial control, among others; none supports a plausible alternative explanation.

This study makes several contributions. By foregrounding the strategic utility of “performing the nation-state” (Mampilly, 2015), it moves beyond macro-level accounts of rebel legitimacy to the micro-level mechanisms through which public performances expand the rebel base. It also speaks to the scholarship on screening and militant recruitment, particularly Hegghammer’s (2013) account of the demand side of recruitment; that is what armed groups do to bring people in. Performative

governance is a demand-side practice that brings the harder-to-reach, by definition outside recruiters’ ordinary networks, into contact with the movement.

Bridging rebel governance and civilian mobilization, I show that symbolic governance is not merely an assertion of authority but a war-making strategy that entails trade-offs. It refines existing theory by demonstrating that governance operates not only through service provision or coercion but also through the production of political legibility. Where territorial control is tenuous, symbolic governance lets rebels identify and mobilize supporters beyond their immediate networks. At the same time, it challenges the assumption that legitimacy-building necessarily enhances civilian support, showing that governance efforts can expand access to new constituencies while exposing civilians to state surveillance and repression.

Beyond the PKK case, the findings carry broader implications. Where traditional explanations of rebel–civilian alignment emphasize preexisting social ties, material incentives, or coercion (Weinstein, 2006; Staniland, 2014; Parkinson, 2013; Lewis, 2017), I suggest that the visibility of rebellion can itself generate mobilization opportunities even absent these factors, with relevance extending beyond insurgencies to nonviolent social movements. They also bear on counterinsurgency and “hearts and minds” efforts, underscoring the need to account for the symbolic and performative dimensions of insurgency when designing policies to undermine rebel influence or foster civilian cooperation with the state.

2 Identification and Information Problems

Rebel groups face two challenges in mobilization. The first is what Kalyvas (2006) terms the *identification problem*: distinguishing supporters from opponents, since the targeted population may include informants, hostile individuals, or government agents alongside potential supporters. The second is what Obayashi (2018) calls the

information problem: assessing the depth of commitment among those already sympathetic, since without screening, rebels risk recruiting individuals with diverging interests or a high likelihood of desertion. These map onto the two trust dilemmas Hegghammer (2013) identifies: a primary dilemma over recruit commitment or quality, akin to the information problem, and a secondary one over the signs that separate a genuine supporter from a mimicker, akin to the identification problem.

Both problems are particularly acute in what I call “harder-to-reach” communities: those beyond rebels’ immediate social networks. Mobilization often begins in familiar circles, where familial, communal, or institutional ties facilitate recruitment (Staniland, 2014; Parkinson, 2013; Shesterinina, 2016). Militancy spreads through extended families and everyday networks, where trust is already established, while political or religious organizations provide additional channels through which rebels can observe potential recruits before enlistment. Such ties help address both problems at once. They reveal who stands with the movement and supply the sustained observation through which a recruit’s commitment can be judged. By contrast, communities outside these networks lack clear markers of loyalty (Obayashi, 2018), confronting rebels with the identification problem in its starkest form: they cannot tell who supports them at all, let alone how deeply.

The privacy of political allegiances (Fjelde and Hultman, 2014) further complicates the identification problem. Rebels may rely on group-level heuristics to locate likely supporters: ethnicity as a proxy (Posen, 1993) or patterns of political mobilization such as election outcomes (Steele, 2011; Balcells and Steele, 2016; Onder, 2024). Yet ethnicity is an unreliable indicator of allegiance (Hägerdal, 2019), and voting, while informative, remains imperfect. Support for a party sympathetic to rebel causes need not imply commitment to violent action, since one may endorse a movement’s goals while rejecting its methods. Voting patterns therefore cannot distinguish passive sympathizers, reluctant supporters, and committed loyalists. Even

where heuristics narrow down who might sympathize, they carry no information about the depth of that sympathy. While established social networks generate ongoing behavioral cues, communities beyond them remain largely illegible to rebels.

I argue that rebels deploy performative acts to render hidden allegiances visible within populations they seek to mobilize. Of the two challenges, identification motivates the investment, whereas information is addressed by what the strategy elicits. In harder-to-reach communities the antecedent challenge is identification. Individuals there may be, in Hegghammer’s (2013, p. 5) terms, “willing, suitable, and biographically available” for recruitment, yet unable to join because no recruiter can locate them. Staging a public act responds to this in the first instance, surfacing who the supporters even are within populations that rebels’ covert recruitment apparatus cannot see. Once staged, the act addresses the information problem. Because voluntary participation under visible state surveillance is costly, attendance separates costly behavioral support from mere sympathy among those who surface, a logic I develop in the next section. By prompting civilians to convert latent, private sympathies into observable behaviors, such acts enhance legibility, letting rebels read and map the political terrain of harder-to-reach communities. Legibility thus spans both layers. It renders supporters visible and their commitment readable.¹

3 Performative Governance as a Strategy of Legibility

Rebel groups engage in highly visible forms of performative governance that mimic rituals and symbols traditionally associated with sovereign authority (Mampilly, 2015), including funerals, commemorations for fallen fighters or key milestones, and

¹Studies of action under repression treat public acts as indicators of how many risk-accepters a population contains (Kuran, 1991; Petersen, 2001). The legibility that performative acts produce concerns *which individuals*, that is, the mapping of individuals onto observed displays of allegiance.

parades. Together with institutionalized forms of rebel governance, such as social service provision, justice administration, law enforcement, or taxation (Mampilly, 2011; Arjona, 2016; Huang, 2016; Stewart, 2018; Revkin, 2020; Stewart, 2021; Loyle, 2021; Gilbert, 2022; Loyle and Onder, 2024), these practices form two components of what the rebel governance literature has largely treated as a single category. Institutionalized governance relies on bureaucratic processes that provide tangible benefits and administrative structures, even when informal or ad hoc (Loyle et al., 2021). Performative governance, by contrast, is primarily symbolic. Hegghammer (2017, p. 3) confronts an analogous problem within militant ideology, decomposing a category scholars had treated as one thing into doctrine and aesthetics, and reasoning that the neglected aesthetic half must do distinct work, or militants “would not bother creating” it. The same reasoning applies to the neglected half of rebel governance. Rather than a cheaper substitute for institution-building, performative acts are staged because they fulfill functions formal administrative tools may not.

Chief among these functions is the production of legibility, which I argue comes from inviting voluntary but costly self-revelation that bureaucratic tools do not necessarily elicit. Paying rebel taxes or accessing rebel-provided services may reveal who interacts with rebel authorities, but not whose support is freely given. Interaction with rebel authorities thus addresses neither the identification nor the information problem. Civilians may comply out of necessity or fear rather than support, so it does not solve identification, and compliance reveals little about the depth of commitment, so it does not solve information. What performative acts add can be illustrated with rebel funerals. A body can be buried without a convoy, a march, chants, politicians, and crowds in the tens of thousands. Everything beyond burial is, in anthropologist Edmund Leach’s terms, “frills,” as quoted in Hegghammer (2017, p. 5).

These frills, however, do carry their own service-like meaning. A funeral binds a family and a community and discharges a moral and spiritual obligation to the dead.

These emotional meanings can matter for who attends. Norms of reciprocity are an engine of participation in risky political action (Petersen, 2001, p. 21), and affect occupies a similar organizing role in the study of militant culture; what matters, Sageman (2008, p. 156-157) argues, is not how militants think but how they feel. Reciprocity, moral obligation, and affect can thus supply the motivation to attend a rebel-aligned event, and sometimes to join the rebel group afterward. Yet the same gathering can do all of this while also functioning as a public display of allegiance. This latter function is what I argue produces legibility. A privately meaningful act of grief that no one observes generates no signal; the same grief, enacted in a mass gathering, does. The crowds draw out participation that is voluntary, public, and costly, and thus readable. The spectacle, in other words, can be the function.

The capacity of these acts to generate information derives from how they are staged. Although these symbolic displays often draw on imagery of violent struggle, such as honoring militants or displaying combat-related symbols, they are nonviolent and deliberately public. By occupying public spaces, rebels maintain visibility and distinguish these acts from the clandestine rebel–civilian interactions that characterize recruitment within immediate networks. Their accessibility invites participation from individuals outside those networks, extending outreach beyond established circles to civilians who might otherwise remain disengaged. In doing so, these acts help address the identification problem by surfacing supporters the covert recruitment apparatus cannot readily see. Among those who surface, participation then carries important information. Observing it allows rebels to distinguish those who merely sympathize from those willing to demonstrate costly behavioral support for rebellion.

Attitudinal sympathy for rebels typically reflects favorable views of their goals (Lyall, Blair and Imai, 2013; Hirose, Imai and Lyall, 2017) or endorsement of political violence (Moskalenko and McCauley, 2009; Kruglanski et al., 2014; Khalil, Horgan and Zeuthen, 2022). But sympathy does not always translate into action. Individ-

uals who share a movement’s objectives may refrain from mobilization due to weak political preferences (Kilcullen, 2009) or risk aversion (Mosinger, 2018). This gap between attitudes and behavior complicates rebels’ efforts to assess loyalty among potential recruits. As Kalyvas (2006, p. 93) notes, behavior itself can also mislead when it is not costly. Civilians may provide intelligence (Fjelde and Hultman, 2014; Condra and Wright, 2019) or pay rebel-imposed taxes (Gilbert, 2022) out of fear or coercion rather than genuine allegiance.

I argue that performative governance helps address these challenges by making participation a more credible signal of pro-rebel allegiance. Voluntary participation in highly visible public events is inherently costly, exposing civilians to the risk of arrest, detention, or torture. This cost stems from participants’ *ex ante* perception of the risk of being identified and punished. When deciding to attend, an individual may not know how the state will later use the record their attendance creates. What they plausibly know is that attending carries the risk of identification. This perceived risk is what sustains the credibility of the signal. Parkinson’s (2023) interviews with participants in Palestinian rebel organizations’ martyr commemorations speak to this calculus. Attendees knew they were infiltrated by collaborators (pp. 100-101) and “consistently reported being afraid and continuing to act” as they spotted potential informers beside them at gatherings (p. 93). This *ex ante* risk perception matters because a public act can separate costly behavioral support from mere sympathy only if performing it is understood to be risky (Petersen, 2001, p. 37). An attendee who did not perceive the risk would be performing a cheap act, and a cheap act reveals nothing about who is willing to bear costs for the rebel movement.

The costly signal therefore rests on two premises, that attendance is chosen and that it is knowingly costly. When rebels solicit but do not compel participation in these performances, participation is free from organizational coercion. Participation that no one formally orders can still be socially compelled where public rituals carry

strong communal norms. But Petersen’s (2001) canonical account of how community norms drive participation suggests such pressure does not blanket a community uniformly. Instead, it travels through specific circuits, such as kin networks, where one member’s participation raises pressure on the rest and where “the desire to avenge a fallen relative can outweigh the preference to avoid risk,” and through oath-bound activist organizations (Petersen, 2001, p. 54). Community norms bind late and bear most heavily on visible nonconformists (Petersen, 2001, p. 55). “Harder-to-reach” communities are definitionally outside these circuits. With no kin in the rebel movement and no roots in activist organizations, they are, in Petersen’s terms, *outsiders* “minimally connected to activities of the community” (p. 50). With no kin network to expect their presence, no activist organization whose norms bind them, and no standing in organized rebel circles that attendance would enhance, social compulsion should have little purchase on them. When individuals outside these circuits nonetheless attend, their participation cannot readily be attributed to social obligation, which is what makes it informative as a signal of allegiance.

Compelled participation, to the extent it occurs, should thus concentrate among those inside the movement’s intimate networks and established circles. The participation of outsiders is what is most plausibly read as chosen. Among these outsiders, only individuals with strong pro-rebel loyalties are likely to incur the risks of participating, allowing rebels to map civilian support within harder-to-reach communities with greater precision. A single public act cannot, however, perform the fine-grained screening of individual commitment that recruitment ultimately requires, and I do not claim it does. Attendance is a coarse, one-shot signal that separates those willing to be publicly seen taking a risk from those who are not.

Performative acts accordingly constitute the front end of the process. In Hegghammer’s (2013) account, recruitment proceeds in stages, from outreach through initial evaluation and probing to costly induction, each soliciting progressively costlier

signs of commitment through sustained vetting. He observes that an individual, regardless of how willing, “will not be able to join unless she is physically located and accepted by a recruiter” (p. 5). Locating is constrained by what recruiters know about potential recruits. Because rebels lack knowledge of every recruit’s loyalties, Viterna (2013) argues, recruiters rely on two proxies: externally assigned identities and network memberships (p. 55), and targeting these identities is what lets them approach people they have never met (p. 49). Both proxies, however, fail for the harder-to-reach individuals, who carry no identity marker that flags them as likely recruits and belong to no network a recruiter works through.

Performative governance helps locate willing but harder-to-reach individuals by supplying a third source of information. It surfaces those the covert recruitment apparatus cannot see and elicits one credible indicator of commitment. The accepting comes later, as finer-grained screening continues downstream through the conventional covert channels the rebel group has always used. As Parkinson (2023) shows, recruitment proceeds through observation in everyday community life, with recruiters working close to home and enrolling people they knew (p. 47), and entry into clandestine roles traveling along specific intersections of everyday relationships and organizational roles (p. 85). The harder-to-reach individual, by definition, has no such intersection. The public act creates the first one. It gathers, in one observable place, harder-to-reach individuals and people holding organizational roles in the rebel movement, who would otherwise never encounter one another, forming what Parkinson calls a *network bridge* (p. 9). Once that contact is formed, recruitment can proceed through the conventional covert channels.

Ethnographic work on rebel recruitment documents how this downstream process operates. Viterna (2013) describes how recruiters in El Salvador ran a first round of evaluations based on observed performance and temperament (p. 75), assigned small tasks through which abilities and trustworthiness were assessed (p. 73), and incor-

porated recruits gradually into the rebel army. Parkinson (2023, p. 104) describes a parallel dynamic in wartime Lebanon, where a young Palestinian man’s publicly witnessed refusal to collaborate with government-affiliated actors increased trust in him and primed him for future clandestine roles. Publicly witnessed costly behavior functioned as the trust input on which clandestine recruitment was then activated. In each case, what feeds the covert recruitment apparatus is the kind of legibility that only public, observable, and risky behavior could have produced.

Institutionalized forms of rebel governance can also generate information about civilian populations, but they are less effective at producing the kind of legibility required to address identification and information problems in contested environments. For one thing, institutional governance may hinge on administrative capacity and repeated interactions, conditions that may be absent where state interference is persistent. Moreover, civilian engagement with institutional rebel governance often reflects necessity, perceived effectiveness, or coercion (Revkin, 2021) rather than voluntary allegiance. By eliciting voluntary and public participation, performative governance instead allows rebels to observe costly behavioral expressions of allegiance and thereby read civilian loyalties under uncertainty.

4 Expanding the Rebel Mobilization Base

By observing patterns of civilian participation in performative acts, including frequency, intensity, and diversity of engagement, rebels can map support beyond their immediate reach and identify pockets of latent support. A more refined profile of civilian loyalties lets them extend recruitment beyond traditional networks². I focus on two groups: women and “harder-to-reach” individuals, by which I mean civilians

²I do not argue that performative acts substitute for traditional recruitment strategies; rather, they function as the front end of a recruitment process whose finer-grained screening continues through covert channels, extending recruitment beyond what those channels could previously reach.

without preexisting familial ties to the rebel movement or strong political activist roots.

Rebel recruitment has traditionally centered on male-dominated networks. Although women do participate in militancy (Manekin and Wood, 2020), cross-national evidence indicates that only about one-third of armed movements include female combatants (Henshaw, 2017; Thomas and Bond, 2015; Wood and Thomas, 2017). Women thus often remain outside conventional rebel circles, whether because groups are reluctant to recruit them or because barriers limit their exposure to clandestine mobilization. Viterna’s (2013) study of the FMLN in El Salvador identifies one such barrier. Recruiters selected on trustworthiness, and women most often became legible as trustworthy only through their relationships to activist men (p. 67). A covert channel that reads women through men leaves a woman without an activist male relative invisible to recruiters, however strong her sympathies.

The public nature of performative rebel acts offers an inclusive mobilization arena by lowering barriers inherent in covert recruitment, which requires contact between recruiters and recruits. Potential recruits cannot publicly seek to join, since a public declaration of interest in violent action invites harm. A recruiter must find them, and recruiters typically look only among people who fit their image of a good recruit. Individuals outside that image go unrecruited “regardless of their level of identification with the movement” (Viterna, 2013, p. 57). A performative act lowers this barrier. Anyone can attend without declaring an interest in joining the rebels and without first matching a recruiter’s profile. The cost of being publicly seen supporting the rebels, however, persists, which preserves the informational value of attendance.

The same act, then, widens who can come within the rebels’ view. Unlike secretive and male-dominated covert interactions, these public performances are open and accessible. A woman’s attendance is not mediated by any man’s standing in

the movement. She becomes visible to rebels through her own act³, engaging the movement in ways less constrained by existing network structures. Through visible and participatory events, performative governance can thus facilitate greater female mobilization than traditional covert methods.

Rebels also commonly rely on familial ties to recruit fighters, a pattern documented across a wide range of cases, including FARC, ELN, EPL, and M-19 in Colombia (Arjona and Kalyvas, 2011), Fatah, the PFLP, and the DFLP in Lebanon (Parkinson, 2013), the PKK in Turkey (Özeren, Sever, Yılmaz and Sözer, 2014; Tezcur, 2016), and rebel groups in El Salvador and Peru (Ortega, 2011). Kinship-based recruitment leaves individuals without family connections less integrated and less visible to recruiters. Public performative acts, conducted in open and observable spaces, can reduce reliance on kinship networks by allowing individuals to signal pro-rebel loyalties independently, enabling rebels to identify supporters who might otherwise be overlooked.

Similarly, individuals without strong political activist roots often remain peripheral to recruitment networks. Some groups maintain close ties to civilian-led political organizations, which they, in Staniland’s (2014) terms, “repurpose” for violent mobilization (p. 17). For example, the ELN in Colombia leveraged civil society organizations to access new militants (Sanin, 2011, p. 188). The PKK in Turkey likewise recruits through legal political organizations (Özeren, Sever, Yılmaz and Sözer, 2014). Prior activist engagement serves as a key pathway into rebellion by fostering ideological commitment (Tezcur, 2016) and social contagion effects (Özeren, Sever, Yılmaz and Sözer, 2014). This activist-based mobilization often excludes individuals with sporadic political engagement, whereas public symbolic events lower the threshold for participation, requiring no prior organizational embeddedness. Volun-

³Rebel funerals may be particularly well positioned among public acts to draw women. People take a first step toward a rebel movement when doing so fits a salient identity (Viterna, 2013, p. 52), and a funeral is gender-congruent in this respect since mourning is coded as women’s work.

tary participation can therefore function as a bridge into the rebel network, enabling rebels to identify previously politically disengaged supporters.

For these harder-to-reach individuals, these events also carry value that those inside the movement’s networks can obtain elsewhere. Individuals with familial ties or histories of activism can be reached by covert recruiters through existing connections, and so do not depend on a public event to be found. For the harder-to-reach, who lack such connections, the event is plausibly the one available route in. It also supplies assurance that those already tied to the movement obtain through their clandestine ties. Petersen (2001, p. 18) observes that “only fanatics will engage the forces of a repressive regime without minimal assurances,” and the harder-to-reach gain the most assurance from attending, since the event offers a credible measure of the movement’s scale and seriousness they have no other way to observe in person. Attendance is therefore worthwhile for them because of what the event offers: access and assurance likely unavailable elsewhere.

The recruitment of such individuals is in fact anomalous in canonical accounts of mobilization. In Petersen’s (2001) framework, organized communities treat outsiders as untrustworthy (p. 50), and people are “unlikely to recruit, or be recruited by, people they have never met” (p. 18), because trust is built from shared history. The reciprocity toward fallen fighters, moral obligation, and affect that likely draw crowds to these events likewise predict mobilization among those already inside the movement’s networks rather than the harder-to-reach. Neither account, then, anticipates the mobilization of individuals without familial ties or prior activism, unless something can manufacture the signal of trustworthiness that shared history would otherwise supply. Voluntary attendance at a rebel-aligned public act under risk can be such a substitute. Hence,

Hypothesis 1. Rebel performative governance acts will increase the mobilization of women and “harder-to-reach” individuals.

5 The Legibility Dilemma

I argue that while performative acts enhance insurgents’ ability to read and map civilian loyalties, they simultaneously expose pro-rebel civilians to heightened state scrutiny, an unintended consequence I term the *legibility dilemma*. On the one hand, these public acts help overcome identification problems by converting private sympathies into observable behavior. Voluntary participation signals a willingness to bear personal risk, allowing rebels to distinguish mere attitudinal support from costly commitment and to identify potential recruits beyond their immediate networks.

On the other hand, the same visibility increases participants’ exposure to state surveillance and repression. Rebel-aligned public events attract security forces, letting authorities concentrate surveillance resources more effectively (Earl, Soule and McCarthy, 2003; Davenport, Soule and Armstrong, 2011). Instead of dispersing efforts across a broad landscape, the state can deploy police contingents directly to event venues. Such concentration facilitates systematic data collection, including visual documentation and the mapping of social interactions, enhancing its capacity to identify, track, and repress civilians displaying overt pro-rebel sympathies (Liu and Sullivan, 2021; Xu, 2021).

Although research on mass protest suggests that dissident mobilization can become safer as numbers grow (Kuran, 1991; Karklins and Petersen, 1993), this logic largely applies to the moment of the act. Large public gatherings provide “some protection from being caught during the act itself” (Petersen, 2001, p. 24), which likely helps keep attendance feasible despite the risks participants perceive. The surveillance associated with performative rebel governance, however, often operates *ex post*. Public events facilitate identification and network mapping that enable later arrests, interrogations, and targeted repression, and the crowd that shields an attendee during the event offers no protection against the records it leaves behind.

Moreover, attending an event and enlisting in the rebel organization’s armed ranks are acts of very different orders of risk. The move between them, in Petersen’s (2001, p. 44) terms, “involves a huge leap in risk acceptance.” The record that attaches to an attendee raises the cost of every further step, joining the rebels above all.

Such records accumulate through several channels. Public events concentrate individuals in one location, making each participant visible while allowing security forces to observe and map social interactions in real time. Authorities can thus infer social networks and identify key influencers within rebel-supporting communities. Individuals occupying central positions in these networks become priority targets for subsequent surveillance or crackdown (Sullivan, 2016). The publicity of these events documents participation beyond the immediate setting. Local and national media, whether pro- or anti-rebel, along with social media, create a lasting public record of attendance (Sobolev et al., 2020). These records, readily accessible to state authorities, can transform fleeting expressions of solidarity into verifiable evidence of political allegiance. Finally, after high-profile events, state authorities can undertake targeted investigative measures, including arrests and interrogations of organizers and participants (Liu and Sullivan, 2021). Such inquiries uncover political allegiances and help the state compile profiles of known rebel sympathizers, extending the reach of its monitoring well beyond the event itself (Davenport, 2005).

The surveillance these events attract is unlikely to be selective at the point of recording; footage, media coverage, and post-event investigation plausibly capture attendees across the board, the “harder-to-reach” included, thereby raising the state’s legibility over pro-rebel civilians. Greater legibility, however, is not the same as repression of everyone made legible. Even states with considerable repressive capacity face limits on how many people they can detain and prosecute, and are therefore unlikely to pursue everyone their records capture. I argue that the state will concentrate its repressive capabilities on those it marks as the most likely threats, people

with familial ties to fighters, records of activism, or prior detentions, because it plausibly builds its expectations of threat around the social ties through which rebel recruitment has historically run. I term this allocation of repression *prior-dependent targeting*, the state allocating its limited repression by its prior expectations of who poses the biggest threat, expectations likely built around the social ties through which rebel recruitment has historically run.

This does not imply that the harder-to-reach escape notice. Their attendance enters the same record, which raises the price of every later step toward the movement and can be acted on at any time; the cost the legibility dilemma attaches to attendance thus falls on them no less than on anyone else. What differs is how quickly surveillance is converted into repression actually carried out. For one thing, the state and the rebels record the same crowd, yet legibility, as Scott (1998, p. 11) notes, requires “a narrowing of vision.” Each actor narrows its vision differently. The rebels read the crowd as a pool of potential recruits, while the state, understanding threat through the channels along which recruitment has historically run, reads it as confirmation of suspicions it already holds, making those it already watches the natural first targets. Realized repression should therefore fall first on the most likely recruits and the covert channels that supply most ordinary recruitment, while the harder-to-reach, recorded but ranking lower, are less likely to be pursued first.

States are documented allocating repression in just this way, by list and by category. Petersen (2001, pp. 143-144) recounts Soviet secret police passing over an individual on a general arrest list they could not recognize while sweeping up the known reservoir of student activists wholesale. The same logic appears with gender as the prior: Parkinson (2023, p. 77) and Viterna (2013, p. 50) describe Palestinian and Salvadoran women moving more safely than men as couriers because the state did not suspect them, a category recorded in plain sight but left unpursued because the state’s threat perception points elsewhere.

Prior-dependent targeting thus concerns *ex post* repression, rather than *ex ante* risk an attendee perceives. The attendee need not know how the state allocates repression or their own standing in its files; what they know is that they will be seen and very likely recorded by the security forces policing the event. That perceived risk sustains the credibility of the signal for everyone who attends, while the state’s priors shape who is targeted first.

Prospective recruits of every kind weigh the risks of arrest or harassment against the benefits of participation (Demirel-Pegg and Rasler, 2021). How much such costs rise, however, plausibly differs by who one is. For individuals with familial ties to fighters or histories of activism, attendance corroborates what the state already holds, and under the *prior-dependent targeting* logic, they are among the first it pursues, so they have the most reason to expect that further steps will be noticed and punished, and the strongest reason to refrain. Heightened repression can thereby constrain the mobilization base despite existing political discontent (Lacina, 2014; Steinert-Threlkeld, Chan and Joo, 2022). Hence,

Hypothesis 2. Rebel performative governance acts will decrease the overall mobilization into the rebel group.

The legibility dilemma thus captures a trade-off. Performative acts can expand recruitment at the margins by drawing in atypical mobilizers previously outside rebels’ networks, while simultaneously deterring a larger pool of potential recruits by raising the costs of participation. The net direction becomes tractable once total recruitment is decomposed into two channels. The covert channel recruits the rebels’ typical members (men, political activists, and individuals with family ties to the movement) at a positive baseline rate. The public events open a second channel, through which the harder-to-reach enter, and whose baseline rate was plausibly near zero because the covert channel does not reach them. A performative act adds recruits through the second channel while provoking the repression that cuts into the first.

The covert channel contracts first because *prior-dependent targeting* directs realized repression at the typical recruits who flow through it, and second because the repression that follows the events can reach the covert recruitment apparatus itself. When the state arrests a recruiter, surveils a safe house, or disrupts a meeting meant to bring together fresh recruits, the channel can contract at its supply end, whatever the risk tolerance of those who might have been recruited through it.

The two channels also differ in how far each can fall. The covert channel runs at a positive baseline and has room to decline. Recruitment of the harder-to-reach begins from almost nothing, so deterrence can shrink the new inflow but cannot push it below zero. The net change is therefore the gain in the second channel minus the loss in the first, and because most baseline recruitment comes from typical recruits, even a modest decline in this larger channel can outweigh the gains in the smaller new one. Even if the harder-to-reach were deterred at a higher per-person rate than typical recruits, the loss in the covert channel can exceed the gain in the new one simply because the covert baseline is large. Both outcomes thus trace to how the state allocates its repressive capacity. The aggregate decline (H2) reflects the withdrawal of those the state pursues soonest, the recruits who have traditionally dominated mobilization, while the compositional shift (H1) reflects the entry of the harder-to-reach, whom the state has less reason to pursue ahead of others.

Consequently, who is deterred in a way that gives rise to H2 follows from the targeted allocation of state repression, since the *ex post* risk each group of prospective recruits faces is shaped by the risk the state's targeting assigns it. One might instead expect deterrence to follow individual dispositions toward risk, with those lacking ties to the movement or prior political socialization presumably more cautious. That inference, from lacking ties to being less committed and so more easily deterred, is less straightforward than it seems. Lacking ties is a fact about whether the rebels' covert channels can see and reach a person. It is not necessarily informative about

how committed that person is or how much risk they will accept. The willingness of those who would join cannot be read off the characteristics of those an organization actually selects (Bueno de Mesquita, 2005, p. 515). Moreover, the thresholds at which individuals join collective action tend to be shaped by the constraints they face rather than by an intrinsic appetite for risk. Petersen (2001) argues, for instance, that young people join early because they are relatively unconstrained (p. 48) and propertied groups join late because of their constraints (p. 49).

Suppose, even so, that the harder-to-reach really are more risk-averse as individuals. Their mobilization can nonetheless rise relative to that of typical recruits, because the risk each group bears is shaped less by their own dispositions than by the state's allocation of repression, which directs *ex post* punishment elsewhere. The legibility dilemma therefore assumes no appetite for risk on anyone's part. Prospective recruits respond to the repression they observe falling around them, and what they observe varies with the state's targeting rather than with any individual's taste for danger.

Formal work on militant recruitment shows that dilemmas of this kind can produce coexisting divergent outcomes. In Bueno de Mesquita's (2005) model of recruitment under screening, a single government crackdown has competing effects on mobilization, and because the people willing to join cannot be identified from those who actually end up joining (p. 515), a fall in overall recruitment can occur alongside a change in its composition, without assuming that those deterred and those newly drawn in are the same people.

The two hypotheses ultimately follow from a single property of the public act. For attendance to separate costly behavioral support from mere sympathy, the act must be costly to perform, since a costless act could be performed by sympathizers and committed supporters alike and would distinguish neither. State surveillance and the risk of repression supply that cost. The same risk that makes attendance a

credible signal is the risk that ultimately contracts overall mobilization, so were that risk removed, attendance would screen no one and deter no one.

A decline in total recruitment is a price rebels can rationally pay when the strategy provides payoffs in the long term. Armed groups confront trade-offs among their varying objectives (McCormick, 2003) and have been shown to trade immediate goals for other organizational goods. De la Calle (2007) asks why an armed group would persist with a violent instrument inefficient for winning mass support and finds the answer in the group's actual objective, the preservation of its local operational capacity, against which the instrument was efficient. The objective I attribute to rebels is of this kind. Rebels stage performative acts to extend recruitment into communities their covert channels cannot reach and to obtain recruits valuable to the organization, while accepting a bounded loss in total numbers.

What the rebels gain from these recruits, beyond their numbers, is threefold. The first is their composition, and with it the organization's operational reach. The events draw in recruits the covert channel does not supply. Because the state's threat expectations are built around its established picture of who joins, individuals outside that picture draw less suspicion and can move more freely, extending what the organization can do in the spaces the state watches least. Second, the new recruits are potentially more secure. Petersen (2001, p. 24) observes that retaliation against informants is central to the development of rebellion, and a public process that screens for costly commitment lowers the probability that any given recruit is an infiltrator. Third, they are plausibly less exposed to preemptive repression. The harder-to-reach carry none of the markers on which prior-dependent targeting runs, so the state is less likely to rank them among its priorities or pursue them first, yielding recruits less likely to be arrested before they can enlist.

Beyond what each recruit offers directly, reaching them opens their surrounding circles to the movement. An individual drawn in from outside the rebels' networks is

connected to family, neighbors, and acquaintances the covert channel previously had no way to reach. Once that individual has joined, those connections become a path along which the covert channel can work, so communities once closed to clandestine recruitment can gradually be brought within reach. The bounded loss in present numbers is thus the price of an investment, since reaching the harder-to-reach today is what makes covert recruitment possible tomorrow in communities the rebels could not otherwise enter.

5.1 Scope Conditions

The legibility dilemma is likely most acute where governments possess greater capacity to monitor and repress. Where the state maintains a persistent security presence, the risks of participation are higher, strengthening both the informational value of participation for rebels and the deterrent effects for civilians. An important scope condition is thus that these dynamics unfold not in exclusively insurgent-controlled spaces, but in contested ones, where neither rebels nor the state exercises full territorial or social control. Contested space describes a particular configuration of the two forms of control⁴. The state holds surveillance reach over the public arena, enough to observe a gathering and to identify and punish those who attend afterward, but lacks the social penetration that would let it preempt the gathering in advance. It may also have reason not to prevent the events even where it could, since under its own reading they are informative, and tolerating and recording a gathering can serve it better than banning one. The rebels hold enough social standing to stage the event, but not the territorial control that would let them push state forces out and make attending safe and unremarkable. Participation therefore remains risky even though the events are permitted.

⁴Petersen (2001, 24) captures this configuration in observing that powerful regimes may control much of the outside world while remaining unable to penetrate local communities easily.

This distribution of control also bears on where legibility-generating acts appear at all. Following de la Calle’s (2007) account of why armed groups deploy particular instruments in particular places, performative acts have little purpose in rebel-held territory, where the population is plausibly already legible to the rebels, and little room in exclusively state-held territory, where rebels lack the capacity to stage them. The contested middle is the only place where the performative act has both marginal benefit and room to operate. It also shapes which act is the costly one. Where rebels hold full territorial control, attendance is the expected default, and abstaining marks a person out. Where the state retains surveillance and *ex post* repression reach, attendance remains the costly act and non-attendance the safe default.

Variation in government capacity to repress can also inform which side of the legibility dilemma dominates. Where the state is marginally more powerful, its ability to act on the information revealed by performative acts is likely sufficient that the deterrent effects of repression outweigh the gains in expanding the rebel mobilization base. Where rebels are marginally more powerful, the state’s ability to translate visibility into effective repression may be more limited, allowing the expansion effects to outweigh the deterrent ones.

6 Research Design

I test my theory on the Kurdistan Workers’ Party (PKK) in Turkey by examining how its public, symbolic governing acts shape civilian recruitment into the insurgency under conditions of contested rule⁵. Launching an armed campaign in 1984 primarily in Southeast Turkey, the PKK is among the longest-running insurgent organizations in the contemporary era. The group has pursued a repertoire of governance practices,

⁵One limitation of the empirical design is that my analyses document the starting point of the process the theory describes (the performative act) and its end point (actual enlistment), while the organizational middle is theorized rather than directly observed.

ranging from justice provision (Loyle and Onder, 2024) to symbolic acts. This makes the PKK a particularly well-suited case for evaluating my theory.

The duration of the conflict generates substantial temporal and spatial variation in both rebel governance and recruitment. The PKK’s operations in Turkey also exemplify contested governance. Although the organization sought to exercise political authority, it never displaced the Turkish state, which always maintained a functioning administrative and security presence throughout Southeast Turkey (Marcus, 2007). The symbolic acts examined were thus staged in spaces the PKK never militarily controlled, bearing directly on the debate, noted in the introduction, over whether rebel governance presupposes territorial control. This coexistence of rebel activity and enduring state capacity situates the PKK case within the scope conditions of the theory, while leaving open whether performative governance actually expands the rebel mobilization base or generates a legibility dilemma.

6.1 Rebel Funeral Rites in Southeast Turkey

Data on rebel funeral rites in Southeast Turkey were collected through large-scale web scraping of *ANF News*, a PKK-affiliated media outlet that extensively covers the funerals of PKK militants and whose close affiliation with the group is well documented (Bundesamt für Verfassungsschutz, 2019, p. 22). *ANF News* provides systematic and comprehensive coverage of rebel funeral rites across provinces and over time that Turkish mainstream media rarely reports on. The concern that such reporting exaggerates turnout is mitigated by the hundreds of cases in which attendance is reported only in the hundreds rather than as mass events.

A total of 569 unique news articles reporting on funeral ceremonies were retrieved and manually coded, yielding a dataset of 481 distinct funeral rites within the study period. Each entry records the precise location of the ceremony across 20 provinces in

East and Southeast Turkey, along with key contextual details, including the presence of politicians, as well as estimated attendance. The dataset also documents state responses by recording police presence, whether confrontations occurred between attendees and security forces, and whether arrests were reported during the event. Further detail on the conduct of these funerals, their organizers, the PKK's public calls for participation, and the full province list is provided in Appendix 24.

Turkish state security forces maintain a visible presence at a substantial number of rebel funeral rites, though direct police intervention, such as dispersal or mass arrests, in these events is rare. Approximately one-third of the recorded funerals involved a significant police presence, indicating that authorities actively monitor these gatherings. However, only 3 percent of funerals resulted in arrests of attendees, suggesting that while the state forces remain vigilant, systematic suppression of funeral rites is very uncommon.

These patterns point to two important dynamics. First, the Turkish state rarely engages in overt crackdowns on funeral rites, implying that civilians are formally able to attend. This feature is central to understanding funerals as a legibility-oriented mechanism of performative rebel governance. Because participation is voluntary rather than forced, attendance functions as a credible signal of allegiance. If the state had consistently banned or violently repressed these ceremonies, many loyal civilians would likely refrain from attending, weakening the informational value of participation. Second, although overt repression is rare, surveillance is common, making participation a costly political act. The presence of security forces exposes attendees to monitoring and increases their risk of future investigation. Monitoring at these funerals is conspicuous. Police presence is visible to attendees, and the funeral data record confrontations between attendees and security forces at the events themselves. The risk of attending is thus not something a participant would need to infer; it is on display at the event. The *ex ante* risk perception that costly signaling

requires is thus built into the event itself. What makes the risk perceptible to the attendee, namely being seen and recorded by the security forces present, is also what delivers the information to the state. By rendering civilian allegiances publicly visible, these symbolic acts can enable the state to map and track potential rebel recruits even as they allow rebels to do the same.

The consequences of attending have also been publicized well beyond the events themselves. Dozens of mayors of the pro-Kurdish HDP were dismissed from office, and in some cases imprisoned, for organizing or attending PKK funerals, and pro-government media circulated photographs of deputies at funerals with their faces circled, demonstrating that the state securitizes the funerals and publicizing the price of attending them (Akin, 2026). The consequences have reached ordinary citizens as well. A university student who attended the funeral of four PKK militants in Diyarbakır in 2006 was identified from photographs extracted from police video recordings of the funeral, arrested, and convicted of membership of an armed organization (*Işıkırık v. Turkey*, 2017). Another citizen was convicted of disseminating propaganda for chanting slogans while attending a funeral (*Korkut v. Türkiye*, 2024). And the police extracted photographs from video footage of a 2008 Diyarbakır demonstration to identify and prosecute a participant (*Gülcü v. Turkey*, 2016), showing that recording a gathering rather than dispersing it, and prosecuting afterward, spans the repertoire of public gatherings in the region. Potential participants could be expected to know these risks. The European Court of Human Rights itself concluded that such convictions carried “a great deal of potential to deter” other members of the public from attending demonstrations in the region (*Işıkırık v. Turkey*, 2017, § 69).

Taken together, funeral rites for PKK militants constitute an important form of performative rebel governance. These ceremonies are public and highly locally visible, creating opportunities for rebels to engage with local communities outside clan-

destine organizational channels. Civilian participation through attendance, chanting, or other symbolic acts signals alignment with the movement in ways that are observable to both rebels and the state. The public nature of these events allows rebels to distinguish between those willing to take visible risks on behalf of the movement and those who remain passive or disengaged, while simultaneously raising the costs of civilian engagement with rebel-organized events through heightened state scrutiny.

PKK funeral rites also offer a valuable opportunity for causal inference due to their quasi-random nature. Although funerals are always held in the hometowns of fallen fighters, their occurrence and timing vary in ways that are plausibly exogenous to local mobilization dynamics. In particular, the exogeneity in their timing is the strongest basis for treating funerals as as-if-random. Even where the location of a funeral reflects past recruitment from a given province (the province must have previously contributed fighters to the PKK to be eligible for a funeral), the precise moment at which one occurs does not reflect that recruitment. A potential concern is that the PKK may strategically stage funerals only when high turnout is anticipated, introducing selection bias. While this possibility cannot be fully ruled out, it is constrained in the PKK context because funeral timing is not easily manipulated. The timing of a fighter's death is unlikely to be systematically related to the political conditions or recruitment dynamics of their hometown. Armed conflict introduces substantial uncertainty, meaning fighters from the same region may die at very different times. Moreover, delays between death and burial are often driven by the state's control over body release. Turkish authorities determine when a militant's body is returned to their family, generating additional variation in funeral timing that lies outside the control of either the PKK or the affected local community. This state-imposed variation is particularly valuable for identification. Because the interval between death and burial is set by an actor hostile to the PKK, the precise timing of a funeral is insulated from the rebel group's own strategic calculations.

In addition, not all communities that contributed fighters to the PKK experience a funeral. Many fallen fighters do not receive public funerals because of tough battlefield conditions, the inability of their families to claim their bodies, or logistical barriers to repatriation, and the exact timing of those that do cannot be anticipated. As a result, while past recruitment patterns determine eligibility for a funeral, neither the occurrence nor the timing of a funeral in a given community is predictable.

In the primary analysis, I focus exclusively on funeral rites with reported *police presence*, as documented by PKK-affiliated media, because visible state monitoring is a central condition for both the informational value of attendance and the legibility dilemma at the core of the theory. The geographic distribution of these funerals is shown in Figure 1. As a robustness check, I replicate the analysis using only funerals reported to have attendance exceeding 10,000 participants. Large-scale attendance plausibly strengthens the recruitment-expansion mechanism by widening the pool of observable participants and lowering barriers to entry for individuals outside established rebel networks. The results are substantively similar (see Appendix 2).

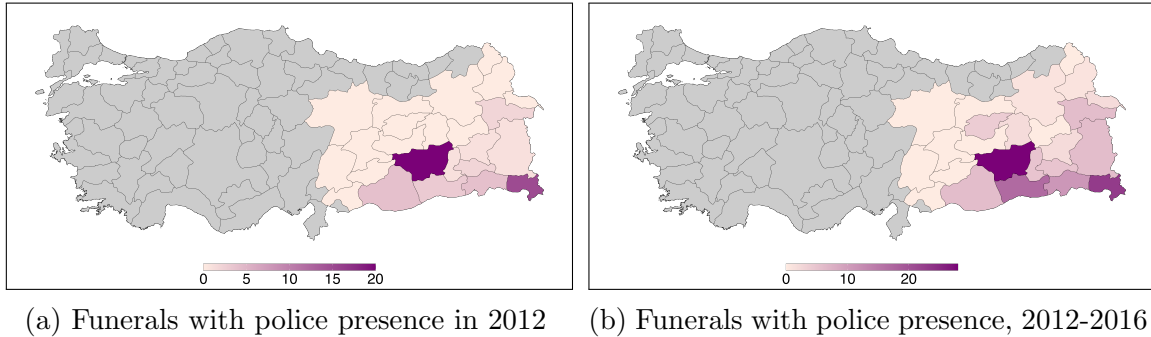


Figure 1: Province-Level Rebel Funeral Rites with Police Presence, 2012-2016

Note: Darker shades indicate more rebel funeral rites.

6.2 Rebel Recruitment in Southeast Turkey

Individual-level records of PKK mobilization are drawn directly from the group’s public listings of fallen fighters. The primary dataset is constructed through large-scale web scraping of the PKK’s official website dedicated to fallen fighters, *hpgsehit.com*, which has maintained public records since 2001. Each fallen fighter is profiled with personal information, including full name, code name, birthdate, birthplace, recruitment date, date of death, and place of death. These records allow for identification of where and when recruits originated, although the level of spatial and temporal granularity is limited to province and year due to data limitations ⁶.

The PKK recruitment dataset spans from 2001 to 2022, covering both pre- and post-funeral rite periods and providing a long temporal scope for analysis. In total, 5,822 fallen fighters were identified. To enrich this dataset, each fighter’s name was cross-referenced with reports from *ANF News*, which publishes obituaries for PKK fighters alongside its funeral coverage⁷. These obituaries are provided directly by the *PKK Basın İrtibat Merkezi* (Press Liaison Center), as openly acknowledged by ANF. A systematic manual coding process was used to extract additional demographic information, including gender, prior political activism before joining the PKK, and whether the fighter had family members in the PKK prior to recruitment. By sys-

⁶Recruitment dates are missing for a subset of fighters, although death years are observed for all individuals. To impute missing recruitment years, I exploit the fact that recruitment-to-death duration is directly observable for fighters with known recruitment dates. Among these fighters, the median lifespan within the organization is six years, with more than half surviving between four and eight years. This relatively tight distribution indicates substantial regularity in fighters’ lifespans, making the median a reasonable and conservative basis for imputation. Accordingly, for fighters with missing recruitment dates, I subtract six years from the observed year of death to estimate the recruitment year. An alternative imputation that instead predicts each fighter’s lifespan from observable characteristics yields nearly identical recruitment-year estimates, and the main results are robust under it, except for the overall-recruitment specification with controls (Appendix 23). A smaller degree of missingness affects recruitment location. When recruitment place is unobserved, I assume that fighters were recruited from their hometowns. This assumption is supported by the observed data, as recruitment location and birthplace coincide in the majority of cases where both are recorded.

⁷A representative obituary is presented in Appendix 24.

tematically coding fighter obituaries, I capture key individual-level attributes in the dataset, enabling an assessment of mobilization trends among women and “harder-to-reach” individuals (e.g., those without prior activism or familial ties to the rebel group) across provinces and over time.⁸

While fallen fighters do not represent the entirety of PKK recruits, potential bias in this dataset is unlikely to pose a significant concern for this study. First, the composition of fighters closely matches known characteristics of the PKK’s broader fighter base. For example, women constitute approximately 30 percent of the dataset, consistent with external estimates of the PKK’s gender composition. Second, it is unlikely that fighters who remain alive are systematically different from those who have died in ways that would bias the analysis. The PKK does not deploy fighters primarily in their home regions. For instance, although most PKK fighters are Turkish-born, the majority of combat deaths recorded in the dataset occurred in Iraq, indicating that fighters are often stationed far from their places of origin. Moreover, PKK members frequently rotate across fronts, sometimes moving to high-intensity conflict zones, such as Syria during battles against ISIS, and at other times to lower-risk areas. As a result, a fighter’s place of origin is unlikely to systematically shape their likelihood of dying in combat.

To empirically test the relationship between performative rebel governance and recruitment patterns, I construct two sets of dependent variables corresponding to the two core hypotheses. To test H1, which posits that rebel funerals increase the mobilization of women and harder-to-reach individuals, I use the following dependent variables:

1. The *percentage of female recruits* measured as the ratio of women to the total number of recruits in a given province in a given year.

⁸Of the properties the theory attributes to these recruits, composition is the one I measure directly. The others (their security, their lower exposure to preemption, and their operational reach) follow from the theory, but I have no means to measure them directly.

2. The *percentage of “harder-to-reach” recruits*, calculated as the ratio of recruits without prior activism or preexisting familial ties to the PKK to the total number of recruits in a given province in a given year.

In complementary analyses, I further disaggregate these measures into the *percentage of female non-activist recruits* and the *percentage of female recruits without family ties*.

The use of ratios rather than crude counts is motivated by the need to account for variation in overall recruitment levels across time and space. By capturing changes in the composition of recruits rather than absolute recruitment levels, these dependent variables allow for a more precise test of whether rebel funerals facilitate the entry of new social groups into the insurgency.

To test H2, which posits that rebel funerals reduce overall recruitment into the PKK, I use the *number of new recruits per 100,000 population* in a given province and year as the dependent variable. This measure adjusts for differences in provincial population size, so that recruitment is assessed relative to the available recruitment pool rather than in absolute terms. Using crude recruitment counts may introduce bias, as larger provinces would generate more recruits even if per capita mobilization rates were unchanged. As a robustness check, I also estimate models using the crude number of recruits per province and year, which yield even larger and more statistically significant declines in recruitment (see Appendix 1). Province-level recruitment patterns are visualized in Figure 2.

6.3 Difference-in-Differences Design

To estimate the effect of performative rebel governance, measured through PKK funeral rites with police presence, on civilian mobilization, I employ a difference-in-differences (DiD) design. Funeral rites occur at different times and in different locations, generating staggered treatment exposure that allows for causal inference. Vari-

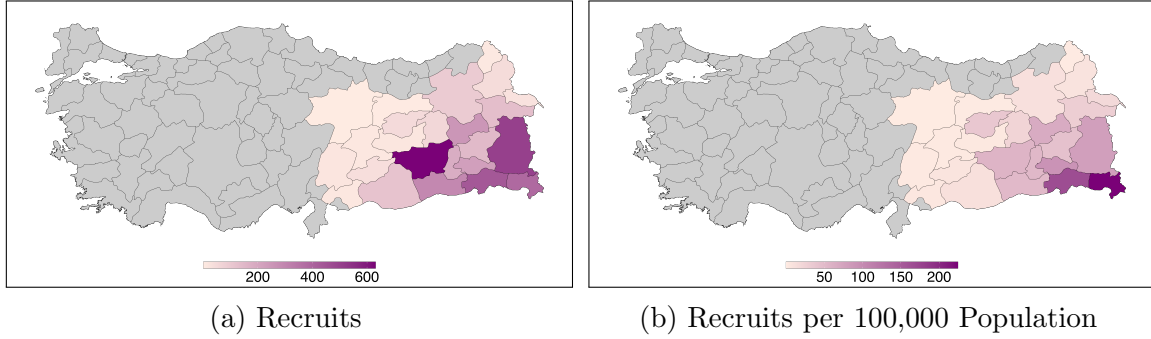


Figure 2: Province-Level Rebel Recruitment, 2001-2020

Note: Darker shades indicate more rebel recruits.

ation in the timing and location of funerals enables comparisons between provinces that experience these events and those that do not, before and after funerals take place.

A key advantage of the DiD framework is that it accounts for time-invariant differences between provinces as well as temporal shocks that might otherwise confound estimates. Funerals are held in the hometowns of fallen fighters, but their precise timing is largely outside the control of local civilian populations. Fighters die under uncertain combat conditions, and delays in state-controlled repatriation further introduce variation in when a funeral occurs. As a result, while recruitment patterns determine which provinces are eligible to host funerals, the occurrence and timing of funerals are plausibly exogenous to contemporaneous mobilization dynamics.

Moreover, not all PKK fighters receive public funerals, often because bodies cannot be recovered from the battlefield. This generates variation in treatment, as some communities with prior PKK ties never experience funerals despite having contributed militants in the past. Comparing provinces that do and do not experience funerals with police presence over time, while controlling for preexisting recruitment trends, allows the DiD framework to approximate a counterfactual scenario in which no funeral occurred.

The *treatment group* consists of provinces that experienced PKK funeral rites with police presence. The *control group* includes Southeastern provinces that had PKK fighters prior to 2012 but did not experience funerals, as well as provinces that hosted funerals with smaller attendance and no police presence. Importantly, some provinces that contributed fighters throughout the insurgency never hosted funerals, plausibly because fallen militants' bodies were not repatriated. These provinces provide a credible counterfactual, as they share a history of PKK recruitment but lack exposure to the treatment.

This comparison allows estimation of how funerals with police presence affect both the composition and the overall level of recruitment, independent of broader province-level characteristics. Because funerals are not systematically assigned, and because their timing is subject to battlefield uncertainty and administrative delay, treatment and control provinces are unlikely to differ in unobserved ways that would bias the estimates. Divergent recruitment trajectories following funerals in treated provinces therefore provide evidence that observed changes are attributable to these symbolic public acts rather than to preexisting differences in rebel support.

To estimate the effects of funerals under staggered treatment timing, I adopt the difference-in-differences estimator proposed by Callaway and Sant'Anna (2021). Unlike traditional two-way fixed effects (TWFE) models, which impose constant treatment effects across units and time, this approach estimates group-time average treatment effects separately for each treated cohort and then aggregates these effects into an overall average treatment effect.

For each province i first treated in year g , the group-time average treatment effect at time t is defined as:

$$ATT(g, t) = \mathbb{E}[Y_{it}(g) - Y_{it}(0) \mid G_i = g], \quad t \geq g,$$

where G_i denotes the first year in which province i receives treatment, $Y_{it}(g)$ is the recruitment outcome at time t if province i is first treated in year g , and $Y_{it}(0)$ is the potential outcome if province i remains untreated through time t . Identification relies on using as the comparison group all provinces with $G_i > t$, including both provinces that are never treated and provinces that are treated in future periods.

6.4 Parallel Trends

The central identifying assumption of the difference-in-differences (DiD) design is that treatment and control provinces would have followed similar recruitment trends in the absence of funerals, so that post-treatment divergence reflects the funeral rather than preexisting differences in trajectories. Figure 3 plots new PKK recruits per 100,000 population by time relative to the funeral year for treatment provinces (those with police-present funerals) and control provinces (those with no funeral or with unpoliced funerals), which should track each other prior to treatment if the assumption holds.

From 11 to 1 years before the funeral, the two groups move closely together, with rises and falls at similar points in time. Treatment provinces sit at higher overall recruitment levels but track the control trajectory closely, supporting the assumption. That higher baseline also makes this a conservative test of H2: since H2 predicts reduced mobilization, any post-treatment decline from an already higher starting point is especially strong evidence for it.

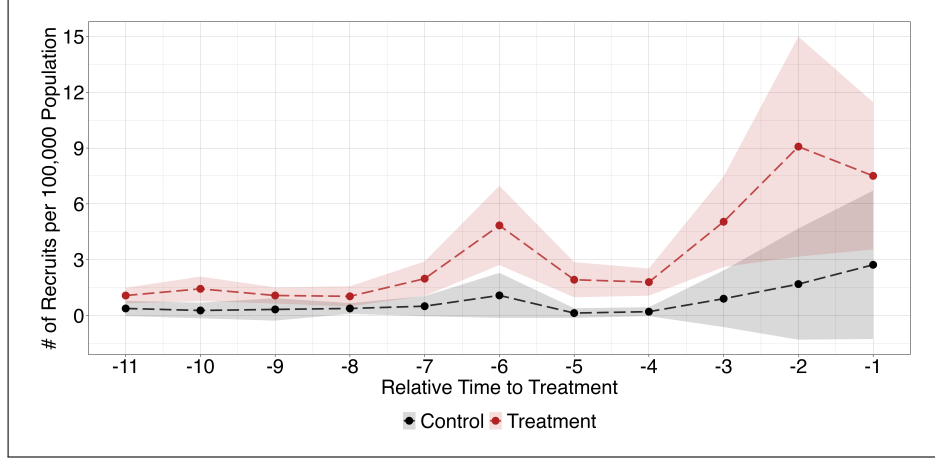


Figure 3: Pre-Treatment Trends in Recruitment

7 Results

7.1 Composition of Recruits

Table 1 reports the average treatment effects on the treated (ATTs) of rebel funeral rites with police presence on the composition of PKK recruits, testing Hypothesis 1. H1 posits that performative rebel governance expands the rebel mobilization base beyond traditional networks by increasing recruitment among women and “harder-to-reach” individuals. Overall, the results provide support for H1.

Models 1, 3, 5, and 7 present naïve specifications that include only province and year fixed effects. Models 2, 4, 6, and 8 introduce a set of controls capturing historical and contemporary security conditions that may shape recruitment patterns. These include the percentage of the rural population, province-level religiosity measured as the number of mosques per 100,000 population, an indicator for border provinces to account for the concentration of PKK activity along Turkey’s borders with Iraq, Syria, and Iran, and historical political dissidence measured by the number of Kurdish tribes that rebelled during the 1920s and 1930s following large-scale

Table 1: Rebel Funeral Rites and Selective Recruitment in Southeast Turkey

	<i>DV: Ratio of:</i>			
	<i>Female Recruits</i> Model 1	Model 2	<i>Hard-to-Reach Recruits</i> Model 3	Model 4
ATT	0.089 (0.089) [-0.086, 0.264]	0.553* (0.126) [0.305, 0.801]	0.020 (0.134) [-0.242, 0.282]	0.409* (0.098) [0.217, 0.601]
Year-Fixed Effects	✓	✓	✓	✓
Province-Fixed Effects	✓	✓	✓	✓
Controls		✓		✓
N	480	440	480	440

	<i>DV: Ratio of:</i>			
	<i>Female Non-Activist Recruits</i> Model 5	Model 6	<i>Female Recruits Without Family Ties</i> Model 7	Model 8
ATT	0.065 (0.091) [-0.113, 0.243]	0.516* (0.135) [0.252, 0.780]	0.081 (0.090) [-0.096, 0.258]	0.542* (0.126) [0.296, 0.789]
Year-Fixed Effects	✓	✓	✓	✓
Province-Fixed Effects	✓	✓	✓	✓
Controls		✓		✓
N	480	440	480	440

Note 1. $*p < 0.05$

Note 2. Robust standard errors clustered on province in parentheses. 95% confidence intervals in brackets.

Note 3. Models are estimated using Callaway and Sant'Anna's (2021) doubly robust estimation method via the `att_gt` function in the `did` package in R. Both "Never Treated" and "Not Yet Treated" units are considered as the control group.

secularization reforms. Data on rural populations are drawn from Tezcür (2016), and data on mosques and tribal rebellions come from Belge and Sinanoglu (2022).

Across all four composition outcomes, the naïve specification (Models 1, 3, 5, 7) yields a positive but statistically insignificant estimate, whereas the specification with controls (Models 2, 4, 6, 8) yields a positive and significant effect ($p < 0.05$): for female recruits, for harder-to-reach recruits, and for the two female subsets (non-activist and without family ties). The estimated ATTs are substantive. For instance, the ATT for harder-to-reach recruits is 40.9 percentage points, consistent with the argument that public rituals lower barriers to entry for individuals who are otherwise

difficult to mobilize.

To trace these effects over time, I estimate event studies of ATTs by event time, where negative values correspond to pre-treatment years and positive values denote post-treatment years (Figure 4). They mirror the Table 1 estimates, with funerals expanding recruitment among women and previously inactive individuals once control variables are accounted for. In Panel A (female recruits), pre-treatment coefficients are indistinguishable from zero, supporting parallel trends; with controls, the effect turns positive and significant in the funeral year ($t = 0$) and remains elevated for at least eight years, indicating a durable shift in female mobilization beyond male-dominated networks. Panel B (harder-to-reach) shows the same pre-treatment null, with positive and significant effects emerging at $t = 3$, a delayed but sustained rise. Panels C and D (female non-activist and female without family ties) are likewise positive and significant post-treatment, indicating that funerals increase the recruitment of women lacking preexisting ties to the movement.

That the effects emerge only with controls merits comment. Province fixed effects absorb time-invariant differences but not differential trends from slow-moving structural characteristics, such as rural settlement, religiosity, and historical political mobilization, that evolve unevenly across provinces. Predetermined with respect to treatment and plausibly unaffected by funerals, these characteristics nonetheless generate substantial residual variance, so conditioning on them improves the precision of the estimated treatment effect. More specifically, rurality, religiosity, and tribal structure proxy for a province’s social conservatism, which plausibly predicts how difficult women in particular are to recruit, since more conservative settings raise the barriers to female mobilization. Because the H1 outcomes concern precisely this dimension, these covariates bear directly on the female-composition outcomes and remove much otherwise unexplained variance.

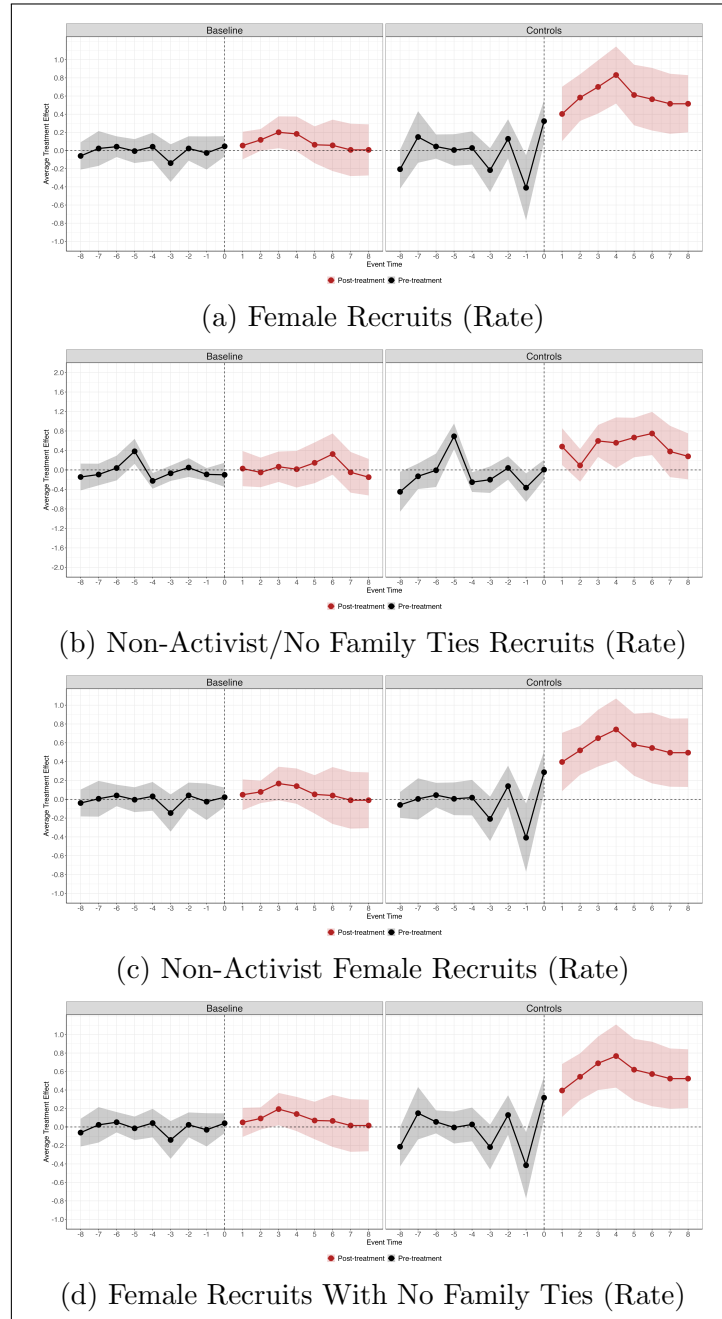


Figure 4: Aggregate Group-Time Average Treatment Effects (Event Study)
Note: The vertical bars indicate 95% confidence intervals.

7.2 Overall Recruitment

Table 2 reports the average treatment effects on the treated (ATTs) of rebel funeral rites with police presence on overall PKK recruitment, testing Hypothesis 2. H2 posits that performative rebel governance ultimately reduces total mobilization as increased visibility exposes pro-rebel civilian communities to state surveillance and repression, deterring some potential recruits from mobilization. The dependent variable is the number of new PKK recruits per 100,000 population at the province level in a given year.

Table 2: Rebel Funeral Rites and Overall Recruitment in Southeast Turkey

	<i>DV: Recruits per 100,000 population</i>	
	Model 1	Model 2
ATT	-4.438* (1.710) [-7.790, -1.085]	-6.067* (2.681) [-11.322, -0.813]
Year-Fixed Effects	✓	✓
Province-Fixed Effects	✓	✓
Controls		✓
N	440	440

Note 1. $*p < 0.05$

Note 2. Robust standard errors clustered on province in parentheses. 95% confidence intervals in brackets.

Note 3. Models are estimated using Callaway and Sant’Anna’s (2021) doubly robust estimation method via the `att_gt` function in the `did` package in R. Both “Never Treated” and “Not Yet Treated” units are considered as the control group.

In both the naïve specification (Model 1) and the specification with controls (Model 2), the estimated ATT is negative and significant, ranging from -4.4 to -6 recruits per 100,000 population ($p < 0.05$). Against an average recruitment rate of roughly 46 per 100,000 across provinces over the full period, this represents a 9.5 to 13 percent decline in overall mobilization. The event-study estimates (Figure 5)

reinforce this. Pre-treatment effects are statistically indistinguishable from zero, supporting parallel trends; the effect turns negative in the funeral year ($t = 0$) and declines sharply thereafter, with significant negative effects persisting for several years. This sustained decline supports the visibility–security trade-off at the core of the theory: public rituals broaden participation among select constituencies while rendering rebellion more legible to the state, reducing overall mobilization.

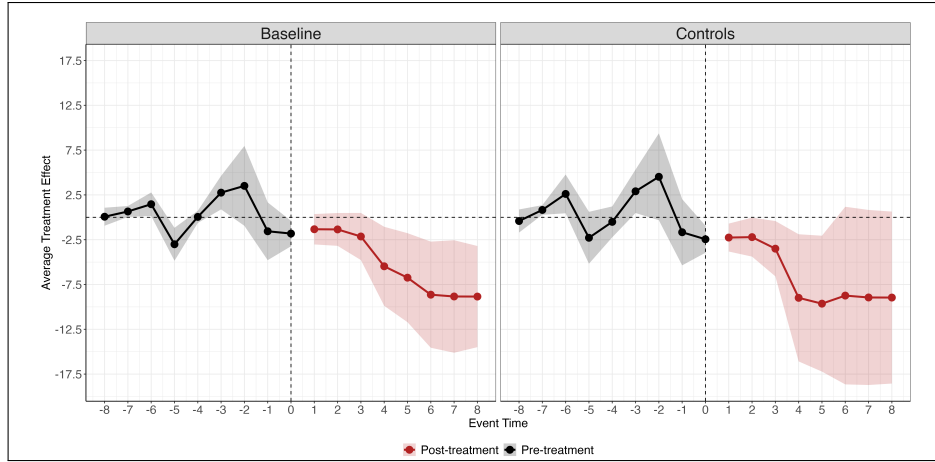


Figure 5: Aggregate Group-Time Average Treatment Effects (Event Study)
Note: The vertical bars indicate 95% confidence intervals

8 Theory-Driven Extensions

8.1 Rebel Propaganda and Path to Mobilization

Consistent with the theory, a structural topic model of PKK-affiliated funeral coverage (Appendix 3) suggests that the group itself frames these events in mobilizational rather than purely commemorative terms. Fighter obituaries point to the same dynamic at the individual level, recurrently describing recruits who attended comrades' funerals, swore vengeance, and subsequently joined the PKK (Appendix 3).

8.2 State Repression

A further implication is that performative rebel governance, by increasing the visibility of civilian participation, exposes pro-rebel communities to heightened state repression. If so, provinces that hosted funerals with police presence should subsequently experience more repression. I test this with original data on state-imposed curfews in 2015 and government-perpetrated civilian deaths during them. Both the number of curfews and the number of civilian deaths are significantly and positively associated with prior funerals with police presence (Appendix 4), suggesting that funeral rites, by rendering support for the PKK publicly visible, inadvertently exposed pro-rebel civilians to state violence.

One counterargument holds that this repression reflects the state's continued inability to distinguish civilians from insurgents rather than improved legibility, with funerals provoking indiscriminate violence driven by persistent uncertainty. A direct test is infeasible, since the data do not record whether victims were perceived as rebel sympathizers, but the two accounts diverge on one observable: if funerals do not enhance legibility, post-funeral repression should be most severe where the state historically lacked local intelligence, whereas my theory predicts no such conditionality. Proxying prior intelligence with the density of village guards, a pro-government militia, I find null interaction effects (Appendix 4). The relationship between funerals and civilian deaths does not vary with village-guard density, which is difficult to reconcile with the counterargument.

9 Ruling out Alternative Explanations and Threats to Inference

9.1 Instrument-Based Reconstruction of Funeral Exposure

To address the worry that funeral occurrence reflects local decisions correlated with mobilization, I reconstruct provincial funeral exposure using individual-level fighter characteristics that shape the logistical feasibility of a funeral (death within Turkey, non-airstrike death, non-winter timing, and median organizational tenure), none of which depend on provincial conditions, and redefine treatment as the first year a province experiences such a “funeral-eligible” death. Estimated on this reconstructed treatment, the staggered DiD results are similar to the main findings (Appendix 10).

9.2 Placebo Tests

A set of placebo tests isolates mechanisms that could shape mobilization but lack the legibility-enhancing properties central to the theory, namely the social reciprocity, moral obligation, and affect that plausibly draw people to these events. Because these forces attach to death and commemoration as such, they should operate whether or not a public gathering occurs, and each placebo test strips the public rebel-aligned gathering from some component of it.

Substituting rebel martyrdom for funerals (the first fighter death from a province) yields null effects on selective and overall recruitment (Appendix 11), as does female martyrdom on female recruitment (Appendix 12); PKK cemetery construction, which commemorates fighters without a public gathering, has no effect on recruitment composition or levels (Appendix 13); and funerals for Turkish security personnel in Kurdish-majority provinces, carrying funerary ritual without rebel content, show none either (Appendix 14). Neither death, commemoration, gender-specific

symbolism, nor funerary ritual absent rebels reproduces the patterns that follow rebel funerals. Reciprocity and affect also cannot make one prediction legibility can: neither anticipates the state-repression response and resulting aggregate decline.

9.3 Other Threats to Inference

I also address a series of further alternative explanations and threats to inference. Funerals are not simply routine governance in rebel strongholds: their frequency is weakly and insignificantly correlated with a survey-based index of PKK territorial influence, and most occur in provinces of low-to-moderate PKK presence (Appendix 5). The state also does not appear to displace funerals across space in ways that would threaten the as-if-random assumption: distance from Malatya, where bodies are released, does not predict funeral frequency, and funeral rates are, if anything, higher where PKK influence is stronger (Appendix 7), while funeral locations do not merely track prior state attention, since perceived state repression is negatively and insignificantly associated with funeral frequency (Appendix 8). Two alternative demobilization accounts likewise find no support: funerals do not cluster where residents perceive the PKK as strong, casting doubt on a success-signaling story (Appendix 6), and the aggregate decline is not an artifact of organizational strain, since PKK foreign recruitment from Iran, Syria, Iraq, and Germany shows no break in level or trend after the peak funeral year (Appendix 15). Finally, the gendered effects are not driven by commemoration of female fighters: restricting treatment to male-fighter funerals reproduces the increases in female recruitment (Appendix 9).

10 Conclusion

This study demonstrates that performative rebel governance, through public acts that mimic the symbolic repertoires of sovereign states, shapes both civilian mo-

bilization and state repression. Using original event data on PKK funeral rites in southeast Turkey, I show that these ceremonies expand recruitment beyond traditional militant networks, particularly among women and individuals without activist backgrounds or family ties to the rebel movement. At the same time, they increase state surveillance and repression, leading to an overall decline in mobilization.

These findings contribute to the study of rebel governance and insurgent mobilization in several ways. First, they extend existing theories of rebel governance by showing that rebels do not require formal institutions or territorial control to govern politically; symbolic governance can shape insurgent-civilian relations by eliciting costly, public signals of allegiance. Second, the study provides systematic evidence that performative acts function as recruitment mechanisms by producing legibility that renders otherwise hidden civilian loyalties observable to both rebels and the state. Finally, the findings highlight an inherent dilemma of rebel governance in contested spaces: while public performances help insurgents overcome informational deficiencies by inducing civilians to reveal allegiances, they simultaneously expose these civilians to surveillance and repression, making the social landscape of war more legible to the enemy.

This study opens several avenues for further research. First, future work should examine performative rebel governance cross-nationally to assess when and where rebels rely on public performances rather than institutionalized governance, particularly under constraints on territorial control and administrative capacity. Second, more systematic research is needed on how variation in state surveillance capacity and information technologies conditions the legibility dilemma. Finally, while this study focuses on insurgent performances, governments also engage in symbolic governance during civil war. Future research should examine state-led public performances, such as martyrdom commemorations, counter-mobilization rallies, or military parades, to assess how states and insurgents compete in the symbolic realm to shape civilian

behavior. Examining how conflict actors strategically manage visibility, not only violence, offers a promising avenue for understanding political mobilization in civil war.

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